What is it, Pa?

He sat down on the edge of the bed. He put a hand on my knee. *Darling boy, Mummy's been in a car crash.*

I remember thinking: Crash…OK. But she's all right? Yes?

I vividly remember that thought flashing through my mind. And I remember waiting patiently for Pa to confirm that indeed Mummy was all right. And I remember him not doing that.

There was then a shift internally. I began silently pleading with Pa, or God, or both: *No, no, no.*

Pa looked down into the folds of the old quilts and blankets and sheets. *There were complications. Mummy was quite badly injured and taken to hospital, darling boy.*

He always called me "darling boy," but he was saying it quite a lot now. His voice was soft. He was in shock, it seemed.

Oh. Hospital?

Yes. With a head injury.

Did he mention paparazzi? Did he say she'd been chased? I don't think so. I can't swear to it, but probably not. The paps were such a problem for Mummy, for everyone, it didn't need to be said.

I thought again: Injured…but she's OK. She's been taken to hospital, they'll fix her head, and we'll go and see her. Today. Tonight at the latest.

They tried, darling boy. I'm afraid she didn't make it.

These phrases remain in my mind like darts in a board. He did say it that way, I know that much for sure. *She didn't make it*. And then everything seemed to come to a stop.

That's not right. Not *seemed*. Nothing at all *seemed*. Everything distinctly, certainly, irrevocably, came to a stop.

None of what I said to him then remains in my memory. It's possible that I didn't say anything. What I do remember with startling clarity is that I didn't cry. Not one tear.

Pa didn't hug me. He wasn't great at showing emotions under normal circumstances, how could he be expected to show them in such a crisis? But his hand did fall once more on my knee and he said: *It's going to be OK.*

That was quite a lot for him. Fatherly, hopeful, kind. And so very untrue.

He stood and left. I don't recall how I knew that he'd already been in the other room, that he'd already told Willy, but I knew.